

POCKET GUIDE · PRICES IN KSH · UPDATED NOVEMBER 2026

10 Weekends Out of Nairobi, Each Under KSh 10,000

Pick one, follow the card, and go this weekend. Getting there, what it costs, how to pay, what to carry and when to go.



Hi, I'm Maria (Mkay)

I'm an ICF-certified travel coach, born and raised in Kenya. I have traveled to 100 countries on an ordinary Kenyan passport and explored all 47 Kenyan counties. I help women 40+ move from scattered travel dreams to clear, realistic plans.

100	47	10	1,300
countries visited	Kenyan counties	weekends in this guide	KSh, the cheapest one

> People tell me they want adventure but aren't sure they can afford it. These ten weekends are my answer: real costs, real matatu stages, and the small things that save you money at the gate.

Which weekend is yours?

START HERE

Going as a couple

A night by the lake and cycling among zebras, tea-country fireplaces, or the Friday train to the foot of Mt. Kenya.

Cards 2, 6, 8

Going with children

Free entry and a boating dam, or crocodiles and colobus monkeys at the Blue Post nature park. At KWS scenic parks, children 6 to 17 pay KSh 250 and under-6s go free.

Cards 4, 3

Only have a day

All within about an hour of town: Ngong Hills, Limuru, Thika and Fourteen Falls, Ol Donyo Sabuk, Machakos.

Cards 1, 6, 3, 10, 4

Tightest budget

Ngong Hills from KSh 1,300, Ol Donyo Sabuk from KSh 1,700, Mt. Longonot from KSh 2,100, all in.

Cards 1, 10, 5

Want a thrill

White water rafting on the Tana, East Africa's longest zip line, or a volcano rim before breakfast.

Cards 9, 6, 5

Want the journey to be the trip

The Nanyuki safari train: KSh 400 each way in economy, through the highlands, every Friday.

Card 8

Going in November or December?

- **Fourteen Falls (card 3)** is at its most impressive just after the rains, March to May and October to November.
- **Sagana (card 9)** has its best rafting water in November and December.
- **Machakos (card 4)** stays warm and dry when Nairobi is grey and rainy.

Before you leave Nairobi

- [ ] Set up eCitizen and link M-Pesa. All KWS parks are cashless and the gate cannot take cash (about 10 minutes to set up).
- [ ] Check your M-Pesa balance: The Forest at Kereita (card 6) is M-Pesa only too.
- [ ] Carry your ID: the entry fees on these cards are citizen adult rates.
- [ ] Small cash for matatus and boda bodas.
- [ ] Leave early: most gates open at 6am and views close in by midday.

The ten weekends

01 Ngong Hills

Nairobi's backyard · 25 km · day trip

KSh 1,300
all in, per person

GETTING THERE

Matatu Route 111 from Railways Stage (opposite Memorial Park) to Ngong Town, KSh 50 to 100. Boda boda to the Forest Reserve gate, KSh 100.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

KSh 200 (citizen adult). The hike only needs the entry ticket. Zip line KSh 700, bike hire KSh 500 for 3 hours.

WHEN TO GO

January to February and June to October. Avoid it after heavy rain: the trail turns slippery and you lose the views.

WHAT TO CARRY

A warm layer (it's cold up there even in the dry season), snacks and water: there's nothing on the trail.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Book your ticket the afternoon before. Pay on the day: matatu and boda.

> **Mkay's tip:** Book the afternoon before to get the earlier 6am gate opening instead of 8am. The morning light on the Rift Valley from the first peak is something else entirely.

02 Lake Naivasha & Hell's Gate

Cycle among zebras · 90 to 110 km · one night

KSh 4,300
to 5,400 per person

GETTING THERE

Matatu from Nyamakima, Odeon or Accra Road, KSh 300 to 500 one way (1.5 to 2 hours). Then the 'Kongoni' matatu to Hell's Gate, KSh 100 to 150.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Hell's Gate KSh 500 (citizen, KWS scenic park) + cycling fee KSh 300. Bike hire at Elsa Gate KSh 400 to 600: bargain a little.

WHEN TO GO

June to October and January to February. The gorge walk may close in heavy rains (March to May).

WHAT TO CARRY

Sunscreen and water for the cycle, a warm layer for the night by the lake, your own tent if camping.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Before you go: park entry on eCitizen (cashless). Pay on the day: matatus and bike hire. Camping at Fisherman's Camp is KSh 900 with your own tent.

> **Mkay's tip:** Start Hell's Gate by 7am for the morning light on the cliffs. At the lake, agree the Crescent Island boat price before you get in.

The ten weekends, continued

03 Thika & Fourteen Falls

A waterfall 45 minutes away · 50 to 65 km

KSh 3,450
to 5,450, one night

GETTING THERE

Matatu Route 237 from Odeon or Ronald Ngala Street, KSh 150 to 300. From Thika, matatu from Makongeni Stage towards Kilimambogo, then boda to the falls.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Fourteen Falls KSh 200 (citizens). Blue Post Hotel nature park KSh 150 per adult: crocodiles, ostriches, colobus monkeys.

WHEN TO GO

The falls are most impressive during or just after the rains (March to May, October to November). The dry season gives clearer access to the riverbank.

WHAT TO CARRY

Shoes with grip for the wet rocks, a plastic bag for your phone near the spray.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Pay on the day: entries, matatus. Book ahead: a guesthouse in Thika or Juja (KSh 1,000 to 2,500) if you stay over.

> **Mkay's tip:** Go early on a weekday: it gets busy on weekend afternoons. Combine with Ol Donyo Sabuk (card 10) for a 2-in-1 weekend.

04 Machakos

Free park entry · 65 km · about an hour

KSh 3,450
to 5,850, one night

GETTING THERE

Matatu from Machakos Country Bus Station near Muthurwa, KSh 200 to 400. Very frequent. Boda or tuk-tuk to People's Park, KSh 100 to 200.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

People's Park and Iveti Hills hiking: FREE. Zip line inside the park KSh 550 (two zips).

WHEN TO GO

Any time. Machakos is semi-arid, so it stays warm and dry when Nairobi is having one of its grey rainy stretches.

WHAT TO CARRY

Sun hat and water, snacks for the children, comfortable shoes for the park paths.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Pay on the day: everything. Book ahead: Machakos Inn, Garden Hotel (KSh 1,500 to 2,500) or Kyaka Hotel if staying over.

> **Mkay's tip:** If the long rains have you feeling cooped up, this is the escape that actually has sunshine.

The ten weekends, continued

05 Mt. Longonot

Hike a volcano · 90 km · day trip

KSh 2,100
to 2,800 per person

GETTING THERE
Same route as Naivasha (Nyamakima or Accra Road, KSh 300 to 500), then boda to the park gate, KSh 150 to 300.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY
KSh 500 (citizen, KWS scenic park). Fully cashless: pay on eCitizen with M-Pesa BEFORE you arrive. The gate does not take cash.

WHEN TO GO
Start by 7am to beat the heat and the afternoon clouds. Rim in 1.5 to 2 hours, full crater circuit another 2 to 3. Gates 6am to 6pm.

WHAT TO CARRY
2+ litres of water (nothing on the trail), proper shoes for the loose-rock descent, a packed lunch.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY
Before you go: entry on eCitizen. Pay on the day: matatu and boda.

> **Mkay's tip:** Pair it with Naivasha: Hell's Gate on Saturday, Longonot on Sunday, back in Nairobi by evening. Three experiences, one weekend.

06 Limuru & Kereita Forest

East Africa's longest zip line · 30 to 70 km

KSh 3,300
to 3,900, day trip

GETTING THERE
Matatu Route 114 from Khoja Stage near Kencom to Limuru, KSh 80 to 200. Matatu towards Kimende, then boda to The Forest gate, KSh 200 to 400.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY
Forest entry KSh 200. 2-line zip (750 m) KSh 1,800 to 2,100, 6-line zip (2.2 km) KSh 2,800 to 3,250. M-PESA ONLY, no cash.

WHEN TO GO
Midweek is quieter. Go before 10am, when the mist sits in the tree canopy.

WHAT TO CARRY
A warm layer for the highland mist, closed shoes for the zip line, a full M-Pesa balance.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY
Book ahead if staying: The Kentmere Club in Tigoni, B&B from KSh 2,000 per person. Pay on the day: entry and zips by M-Pesa.

> **Mkay's tip:** The forest is at its most magical in the early morning, with mist in the canopy. The whole thing is very cinematic.

The ten weekends, continued

07 Nakuru & Menengai Crater

A KSh 200 volcanic caldera · 160 km

KSh 3,600
to 6,100, one night

GETTING THERE

Matatu or shuttle from Accra Road, Tea Room or Muthurwa, KSh 400 to 700 one way (2.5 to 3 hours). Easy Coach or Greenline KSh 1,000 to 1,200.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Menengai Crater KSh 200 (Kenya Forest Service). Hyrax Hill site and museum KSh 100. Lake Nakuru NP is extra: KSh 1,500 per citizen adult + KSh 600 per small car.

WHEN TO GO

January to March and June to October.

WHAT TO CARRY

Hiking shoes and water for the crater rim, a light jacket for the evening.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Before you go: Lake Nakuru NP on KWSPay (if adding it). Book ahead: an Airbnb or guesthouse (from KSh 1,300). Pay on the day: Menengai and Hyrax Hill.

> **Mkay's tip:** Try Gilani's, a Nakuru institution for decades. Going up on a Friday evening? The 2NK shuttle from Tea Room is reliably on time.

08 Nanyuki & Mt. Kenya Foothills

Ride the KSh 400 train · 180 to 200 km

KSh 3,400
to 5,000, one night

GETTING THERE

Safari train every Friday 9am, arrives 4:49pm; back Sunday 9am, arrives 4:46pm. KSh 400 economy, KSh 1,000 first class. Or matatu (4NTE, Chakana) KSh 700 to 1,000.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Mt. Kenya National Park KSh 800 per 24 hours (citizen). Public campsite KSh 200 a night. All fees on KWSPay (cashless).

WHEN TO GO

Clearest views January to March and July to September. Cloud rolls in by midday, so be on the trail before 9am.

WHAT TO CARRY

A warm, waterproof layer even in July: altitude and Kenyan weather are unpredictable together.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

The train is NOT on the SGR booking site: call Kenya Railways on 0709 907 000 to confirm it's running and how to buy. Park fees on KWSPay before you go.

> **Mkay's tip:** Stand on the equator line in Nanyuki: the photo costs nothing. Trout Tree Restaurant is the bucket-list lunch if you can stretch it.

The ten weekends, continued

09 Sagana

Kenya's only white water rafting · 95 km

KSh 7,900
to 10,000, one night

GETTING THERE

Nyeri-bound matatu from Tea Room or Accra Road, alight at Sagana, KSh 300 to 500 (1.5 to 2 hours). A shared car is easier if you can split fuel.

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

Short rafting (1 to 2 hours) about KSh 5,500, long rafting KSh 7,750, bungee KSh 3,000 to 5,000. Camping KSh 1,000 to 2,000.

WHEN TO GO

Best rafting water April to May and November to December, after the rains. Dry season rapids are calmer but still fun.

WHAT TO CARRY

Clothes you can get wet, a change of clothes, sandals that strap on, sunscreen. Self-catering supplies from Nairobi save the most.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Call the camps directly (Rapids Camp, Savage Wilderness): their direct rates are often better than online. Groups of 4+ can negotiate packages.

> **Mkay's tip:** On the tightest budget, skip the rafting and do river trekking, rock climbing and a campfire night. The scenery alone is worth it.

10 Ol Donyo Sabuk

The hidden gem · 65 km · day trip

KSh 1,700
to 2,000 per person

GETTING THERE

Thika-bound matatu (Route 237, KSh 150 to 300), then a matatu towards Kilimambogo (KSh 100 to 200) and a boda to the park gate (KSh 100 to 200).

ENTRY AND HOW TO PAY

KSh 500 (citizen, KWS scenic park). Fully cashless: eCitizen and M-Pesa only. A KWS ranger guide goes with every hiker (buffalo are common).

WHEN TO GO

Summit hike about 5 hours return: start before 9am. On a clear day you see Mt. Kenya to the north and Kilimanjaro to the south.

WHAT TO CARRY

2+ litres of water, a rain jacket whatever the season (the upper forest is dense and wet), a packed lunch.

BOOK AHEAD OR PAY ON THE DAY

Before you go: entry on eCitizen. Pay on the day: matatus and boda.

> **Mkay's tip:** Day one Fourteen Falls and Blue Post Hotel, day two an Ol Donyo Sabuk sunrise hike: two different landscapes, well under KSh 6,000.

When to go

SEASONS AT A GLANCE

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
1 Ngong Hills	■	■				■	■	■	■	■		
2 Naivasha & Hell's Gate	■	■				■	■	■	■	■		
3 Thika & Fourteen Falls			▬	▬	▬					▬	▬	
7 Nakuru & Menengai	■	■	■			■	■	■	■	■		
8 Nanyuki & Mt. Kenya	■	■	■				■	■	■			
9 Sagana rafting				▬	▬						▬	▬

■ best months, from my guide ▬ best water (falls and rapids, after the rains)

Kenya has rains, not summer and winter. The long rains fall around March to May and the short rains around October to November. Trails get slippery and gorges can flood, so check the forecast the day before.

Machakos stays warm and dry when Nairobi is having a grey, rainy stretch. **Mt. Longonot** and **Ol Donyo Sabuk**: start by 7 to 9am, before the heat and the clouds. **Limuru** is at its most magical in the early-morning mist, before 10am.

Pack for every weekend

- [ ] A warm layer: Ngong, Limuru and Nanyuki are cold even in the dry season
- [ ] A rain jacket, whatever the season
- [ ] 2 litres of water per person for hikes: there is nothing on the trails
- [ ] Proper shoes: Longonot's descent is loose rock
- [ ] Packed lunch and snacks
- [ ] Phone charged, eCitizen open, M-Pesa topped up
- [ ] ID for citizen rates

Extra in the rainy months

- [ ] Shoes with grip, and a spare pair of socks
- [ ] A dry bag or plastic bag for phone and ID
- [ ] A plan B: Machakos or Thika instead of a muddy hike
- [ ] Check that Hell's Gate gorge is open: it can close in heavy rain

Extra for overnight

- [ ] Your own tent if camping (Fisherman's Camp, Ngong, Mt. Kenya)
- [ ] Headtorch and a warm sleeping layer

Planning something bigger than a weekend?

If it's your first trip on your own, or you keep saying "one day", talk it through with me. A short call turns it into a date, a budget and a short list of next steps.

FREE

Check-in chat

A free 30-minute phone call with me to talk through the trip you have in mind.

Book a free chat

Scan to book on your phone

USD 10

Pre-Trip Confidence Call

30 minutes with me on your actual plan. Pay by M-Pesa or card, then pick a time on my calendar straight away.

Book the USD 10 call

Scan to book on your phone



Enjoy the weekend. Send me a photo from the top.

Maria (Mkay) · @travelwithmkay · travelwithmkay.co.ke

More free guides on my blog

- [ ] My 2-day Naivasha itinerary, hour by hour
- [ ] Camping sites near Nairobi: costs, routes and what to pack
- [ ] How to build a travel budget you will keep

Prices come from my guide "Weekend Getaways from Nairobi Under KSh 10,000", last updated 3 November 2026. Entry fees are citizen adult rates. Fares, fees and schedules change, so check the official source (KWS, Kenya Railways, the operator) before you pay.